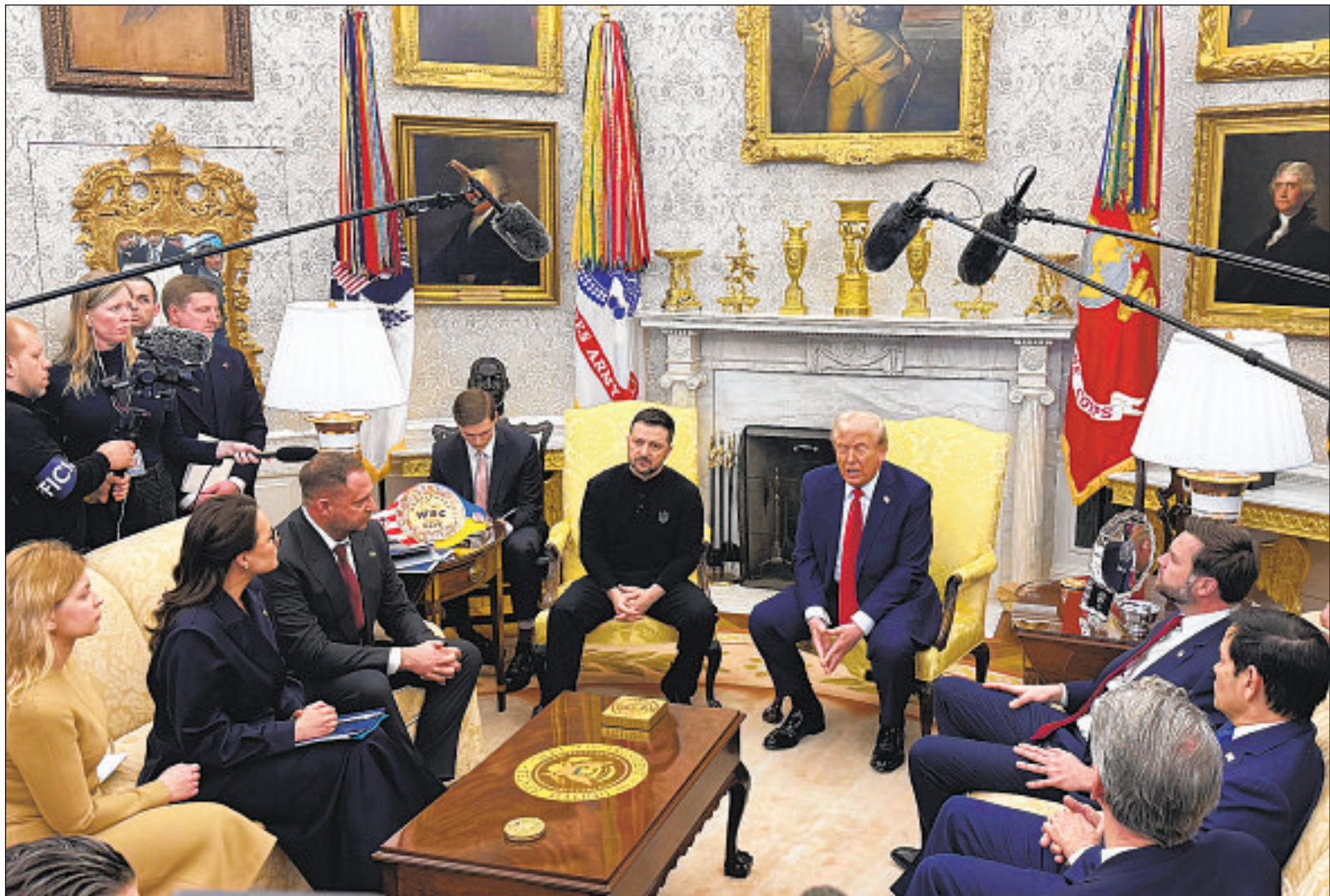




AFTER Ukrainian leader Volodymyr Zelensky, center left, said Friday that he “will never accept just cease-fire” with Russia, President Trump lashed out: “You’re either going to make a deal, or we’re out. And if we’re out, you’ll fight it out. ... But you don’t have the cards.”

Trump and Vance berate Zelensky in heated Oval Office gathering

In unprecedented diplomatic display, they attack Ukrainian leader as an ungrateful ally

By FAITH E. PINHO
AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — An extraordinary diplomatic rupture unfolded in the Oval Office on Friday when President Trump and Vice President JD Vance publicly berated Ukraine’s president, Volodymyr Zelensky, as an ungrateful ally risking global war in its ongoing defense against Russian invaders.

Trump and Zelensky opened their meeting, scheduled around the planned signing of a joint agreement on access to Ukraine’s rare-earth minerals, with complimentary terms, hailing the deal as a concrete

American investment in Ukraine’s future.

But tensions quickly boiled over in unprecedented fashion when Vance accused the Ukrainian president of undermining Trump in public.

“I think it’s disrespectful for you to come to the Oval Office to try to litigate this in front of the American media,” Vance said. “Have you said ‘thank you’ once?”

Zelensky’s first words to the president at the meeting were, “Thank you so much, Mr. President. Thank you for the invitation.”

Zelensky had told Trump that Russian President Vladimir Putin could not be trusted, that Putin’s

territorial ambitions had to be stopped, and that Ukraine would require security guarantees in any deal to end the war.

“We will never accept just [a] cease-fire,” Zelensky said. Kyiv has repeatedly warned that freezing the battlefield would allow Moscow to fortify its positions, entrench in occupied territory and rearm to come back for more.

The remarks prompted Trump to accuse Zelensky of lacking appreciation for U.S. assistance.

“You can’t make any deals without compromises,” Trump said. Both Trump and Vance warned Zelensky that Ukraine is running low on soldiers.

“The problem is, I’ve empowered you to be a tough guy. And I don’t think you’d be a tough guy without the United States,” Trump said. “Your people are very brave. You’re either going to make a deal, or we’re out. And if we’re out, you’ll fight it out — I don’t think it’s going to be pretty, but you’ll fight it out. But you don’t have the cards.”

“Once we sign that deal, you’re in a much better position,” Trump added. “But you’re not acting at all thankful, and that’s not a nice thing.”

“I’m not playing cards,” Zelensky said.

“You’re not really in a good position.” [See U.S.-Ukraine, A6]

Mexican officials try to cope with the new tariff in town

Sheinbaum is working to persuade Trump to hold off on potential threat to economy.

By PATRICK J. McDONNELL
AND KATE LINTHICUM

MEXICO CITY — Facing a Tuesday deadline, the government of Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum is

once again mounting a full-court press to dissuade President Trump from implementing potentially devastating tariffs on Mexican exports to the United States.

This week, she delivered a symbolic gift: the transfer to the United States of 29 drug trafficking suspects, including Rafael Caro Quintero, the legendary co-founder of the once-dominant Guadalajara cartel and alleged mastermind of the 1985 slaying of Enrique

Camarena, an undercover U.S. Drug Enforcement Administration agent in Mexico.

Also flown to the United States in a dramatic illustration of binational security collaboration were alleged drug lords affiliated with some of the six Mexican organized crime groups that Trump’s White House branded “foreign terrorist organizations.”

Behind closed doors in Washington, several of

Sheinbaum’s Cabinet ministers engaged in a different form of diplomacy, seeking to persuade their U.S. counterparts to stave off Trump’s plan for a 25% across-the-board tariff on goods from Mexico and Canada. Sheinbaum, meanwhile, said she was hoping to speak directly to the mercurial U.S. president.

“As you know, he has his way of communicating,” Sheinbaum said Thursday with a smile. “But, as we al-

ways say: It takes a cool head and optimism to reach an accord.”

Trump first threatened to impose tariffs on Feb. 4, but last-minute agreements delayed them a month. On Wednesday, Trump seemed to say that the tariffs would be deferred again — until April. But in a social media post Thursday, Trump again reversed course, saying they would go into effect on March 4.

[See Mexico, A4]

For many small businesses, the Oscars are golden

Florists, limo services, hotels, caterers, others cash in on the biggest night for Hollywood.

By SAMANTHA MASUNAGA
AND SANDRA McDONALD

For more than 20 years, Sherman Oaks florist Mark’s Garden has designed the towering greenery and blooming displays seen at the Oscars.

Getting that Hollywood awards-season work is key, particularly during the business’ typically slow first quarter of the year. And the free advertising that comes with your floral arrangements gracing the year’s big-

gest stage? Priceless.

“People love being associated with the florist that designs for the Oscars,” owner Michael Uncapher said. “It has shaped our reputation in a way no marketing campaign ever could.”

A report commissioned by the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences estimated that the economic effect of last year’s Oscars and related events was \$134 million in Los Angeles County, when using conservative estimates for visitor counts, average hotel rates and personal spending.

Last year, the nonprofit reported that its “Academy Awards and related activities” brought in about \$147 million in revenue, which in-

[See Oscars, A8]



MARK’S GARDEN created this installation for the 2024 Oscars. “People love being associated with the florist that designs for the Oscars,” its owner says.

Cuts at weather agencies spark alarm

Scientists worry about harm in all facets of providing crucial climate information.

By GRACE TOOHEY

As federal job eliminations strike the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration and the National Weather Service, scientists and environmental advocates are denouncing the cuts, saying they could cause real harm to Americans.

About 5% of NOAA employees stationed around the U.S. — approximately 650 staffers — received a termination email Thursday, according to White House and congressional officials. The cuts shrank teams across all facets of the climate-focused agency, from experts working on weather forecasting, ocean health, climate change, fisheries and developments in space and the atmosphere.

“People nationwide depend on NOAA for free, accurate forecasts, severe weather alerts, and emergency information,” Rep. Jared Huffman (D-San Rafael), the ranking member of the House Natural Resources Committee, wrote in a statement. “Purging the government of scientists, experts, and career civil servants and slashing fundamental programs will cost lives.”

NOAA — which includes the National Weather Service, National Hurricane Center and the Tsunami Warning Center — is the latest in a string of federal agencies targeted for cuts by the Trump administration. An administrative official, who spoke on background, said that the cuts at NOAA were part of “an extensive process ... conducted to ensure that mission-critical functions to fulfill the NOAA’s statutory responsibilities weren’t compromised,” noting that weather service meteorologists were largely spared.

However, there were at least some weather service employees included in the cuts, including in California, according to KQED.

[See Weather, A10]

English may be official language

President Trump was expected to sign an executive order making it the law in the U.S. **NATION, A5**

Libraries can be havens in L.A.

Anyone can receive immigration expertise at some locations via a city-funded program. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Stafford secures new Rams deal

Veteran quarterback reaches agreement on restructured contract amid talk of potential departure. **SPORTS, B12**

Weather

Low clouds clearing. L.A. Basin: 65/53. **B8**

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